

Takeaways

- **The TMC finally announces a vital list of district heads, with 2026 polls looming**
- **The roster was stuck for a year due to differences in approach between Mamata, Abhishek**
- **The final choices reflect a belated but careful compromise**
- **Nervousness has grown due to the barrage of scams**

▶ WEST BENGAL

THE BANERJEES IN A BALANCE

Mamata's old guard and Abhishek's reformist bloc strike a deal on who mans the districts to gear up for the uphill task of winning 2026 state polls

had a handsome score of 29 out of Bengal's 42 Lok Sabha seats last summer, with a 2 per cent vote swing in its favour, and ramped that up to a knockout-worthy 14 per cent-plus in November bypolls, where it swept all six seats in play, even plucking two out of the BJP's kitty.

NEW COAT OF TAINT

Why so? Because, while corruption has historically not inflicted electoral damage on the TMC, a new nervousness is now evident. Just a day before the list was announced, there was public backlash over a police crackdown on protesting School Service Commission (SSC) teachers in Salt Lake. The situation worsened when former TMC MLA Sabyasachi Dutta was allegedly seen assaulting demonstrators and journalists. Fired SSC teachers, who see themselves as unfairly victimised in a 2016 recruitment scam, are only one piece of collateral damage in what has been a barrage of scandals over the years—from the Saradha and Rose Valley chit fund scams to the coal and cattle smuggling rackets.

In 2021, the BJP's vociferous campaign centred around "cut money" and "syndicate raj" failed to stop a resounding TMC victory. But this time, the party's apparent inertia, prolonged decision paralysis and a growing perception of arrogance have contributed to a sense of strategic drift.

The negotiated settlement on the district personnel aims to change that. Among the most notable examples of compromise is Howrah Urban organisational district, where veteran leader and minister Arup Roy has been appointed president. Roy was not the preferred candidate of either faction, but with no other consensus leader available, Mamata pressed for the selection of her cabinet colleague, and Abhishek agreed.

In North Kolkata, the newly constituted nine-member core committee reflects a more evenly distributed balance of power. It includes figures from both camps—such as Jiban Saha, widely seen as close to Abhishek—while MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay has been accommodated as chairperson. Birbhum is the only other district to get such a committee and designated chairperson. Across the state's 35 organisational districts, 16 have received new appointees. Two are pending: Darjeeling (Plains) and North 24 Parganas (Barasat). For all other districts, both a president and a chairman have been named.

"It was high time the ball was set rolling. We were all getting worried. Unless the reshuffle was done, nothing else would have moved," says a senior TMC functionary. Yet many feel it has come too late. Says political analyst Biswajit Bhattacharya, "By this time in 2020, if you remember, the TMC was in full campaign mode for 2021. It had the campaign song and theme ready—even amid the pandemic. But this time, they are already very late. The PM and home minister begin their campaign soon."■